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Rails to Trails phase 2 starts

Engineers inspecting abandoned tunnels

September 26, 2010 - By ZACH MACORMAC, For The Weirton Daily Times

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WHEELING - Phase two of the Wheeling Rails to Trails project is now under way.

With 16 miles of completed trails running through each ward of the city, Wheeling engineers can now branch the trail to the next frontier - abandoned railroad tunnels.

When finished, phase two will connect the existing river trail in front of Mull Machine Co. across state Route 2, through the two north tunnels to a rail bridge, under McColloch's Leap to the Peninsula Industrial Park area, and then to both sides of Tunnel Green, according to R. "Scat" Scatterday, manager and project engineer for the Wheeling-Ohio County Rails to Trails.

Gordan Elliott, an engineering consultant with Appletree Construction Solutions, took time to inspect the two north tunnels - the 587-foot Top Mill Tunnel and the 1,203-foot Mount Wood Tunnel - on Thursday. Guiding him along the paths were Scatterday, project scientist Ben Stout, engineering technician Mike Stahl and Carl Wilson, engineering technician.

The purpose of Elliott's visit was to assess each tunnel and provide his professional insight for corrective solutions for both tunnels. In particular, he inspected a 150-foot collapse inside the Mount Wood Tunnel.

"The idea of (phase two) is to connect history with the present and, of course, the future," Scatterday said. "In the early 20th century, those tunnels were used by 100-plus trains per day along with several hundreds of people who would walk to work from Martins Ferry across the Ohio River Railroad Bridge, which was demolished in the late '90s."

He said his team is replacing the tracks with a bike trail so hundreds of people today and in the future can visit the expansive history of the railroad system.

"Specifically, inside of each turn - spaced every 60 feet - are cutouts in the side walls of the tunnels that were 3 feet wide, 2 1/2 feet deep and 7 feet tall where tunnel walkers could seek shelter from the passing trains," Scatterday noted.

Currently, the Rails to Trails team is awaiting cost estimates for tunnel repairs from Elliott.

When completed, Scatterday and his crew can apply for grants to pay for the project.

If enough grant funding is obtained, a proposition will appear before Wheeling City Council, which, Scatterday said, already gave full



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support to the project. Upon approval, phase two can begin. Scatterday said the process prior to construction will probably take about a year.

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